



In his 670 days in the ministry, Maken has undertaken personal visits to Malaysia, Thailand and Singapore spending about 12 days in those countries last June.

Ajay Maken, MoS for urban development

Dasmunshi has spent 38 days on his personal visits abroad against 20 days on official tours. He has covered 1.59 lakh km during his ministerial term.

◀ Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi, minister for I&B and parliamentary affairs

The UPA regime has steadfastly refused to reform the education sector by opening it to foreign direct investment. Yet that has not prevented the ministers and the mandarins from catching flights to various corners of the world. Purandeswari in her 670 days in office made eight trips while her Cabinet Minister Arjun Singh went abroad nine times including an eight-day trip to the Middle-East. The ministry sources say that Purandeswari "presents the case of India very well at the international fora".

In many instances, the connection between the destination and the portfolio is difficult to decipher. Why would an MoS for

commerce and textiles visit Uzbekistan thrice? Or what is the attraction of Serbia for ministers? Although there are entitlement norms for a minister travelling abroad, they are known to demand that they be lodged at the best suites and travel in the most expensive wheels. Simply because there is the peculiar political fig leaf called convention whereby ministers can justify expenditure with the profligacy of a previous regime.

While official work is a very useful alibi, it is interesting to note that certain destinations are visited by ministers regardless of their portfolio. Information reveals that 17



Mukherjee's previous portfolio of defence had fetched him 12 trips abroad while he has made 21 trips being the external affairs minister.

Pranab Mukherjee

Minister for external affairs

Days as minister: 1,287

NUMBER OF TRIPS: 33

Official: 33

Personal: Nil

DAYS ABROAD: 115

Official: 115

Personal: Nil

Km travelled: 3,09,145

Official: 3,09,145 km

Personal: Nil

OFFICIAL EXPENSES*:

Rs 86 lakh

**Only for MEA's 21 trips*